

What's It Like To Climb A Skyscraper?

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Alex Honnold ha battuto il record di scalata di grattacieli raggiungendo la cima (senza alcuna protezione) del Taipei 101 di Taiwan, alto 508 metri. L'americano è uno dei pochi praticanti di questo controverso sport.



Alex Honnold, a rock [climber](#) who was the subject of the Oscar-winning documentary *Free Solo*, successfully climbed the 1,667-foot-tall (508m) [skyscraper](#) Taipei 101 in Taiwan on Sunday, without a [rope](#). Scaling a building that tall is not like climbing a mountain. Those in the club of just a dozen or so known [skyscraper climbers](#) worldwide say the activity comes with unique physical and mental demands. It is also a largely underground sport because it is usually illegal. Alain Robert, a Frenchman who has scaled some two hundred buildings since the 1990s, mostly with his [bare hands](#), said that he has been arrested more than 170 times. “You feel like you’re literally in a movie,” Robert said, with “cops that are trying to catch the bad guy climbing the building.” The obvious risks make it rare for someone to obtain permission to climb a tall building, as Honnold did. His climb Sunday was broadcast live on Netflix. “I’ve never been [willing to](#) get arrested,” the forty-year-old said in a podcast recorded before the climb. Unlike the serene natural landscape surrounding [climbers](#) on routes like El Capitan in Yosemite National Park, which Honnold scaled in 2017, [skyscraper climbers](#) must [overcome](#) urban noise, crowds and, occasionally, police officers determined to arrest them. “You feel like King Kong in the city,” said Titouan Leduc, twenty-four, a French [climber](#) who scaled Varso Tower in Warsaw, Poland, the tallest [skyscraper](#) in the European Union, last year. He was briefly arrested after that. Those who have climbed [skyscrapers](#) say their bodies face different demands compared with rock climbing. According to Dan Goodwin, who in 1986 climbed the CN Tower in Toronto — then the tallest structure in the world — [skyscraper](#) climbing mainly [comes down to](#) repetitiveness versus variety. On a [rock face](#), each move presents a new [puzzle](#): [climbers](#)’ hands search for different [holds](#) — [crimps](#), [jugs](#), [slopers](#) — and they constantly adapt their bodies. But along the side of a building, [climbers](#) repeat the same few movements hundreds of times to pass over dozens of [stories](#) of windows, steel bars and [concrete gaps](#). “You can do a [pullup](#) and think it’s not all too bad, but try doing twenty, fifty, one hundred,” Goodwin said. “Doing the same kind of move over and over and over — it can really [tax](#) your muscles and fingers.” Culture

Skyscrapers: The Sky Is The Limit I grattacieli sono un fenomeno moderno apparso alla fine del XIX secolo. Da allora, i progressi della tecnologia e dei materiali hanno ridisegnato il profilo delle grandi capitali mondiali. Conor Gleeson , Sarah Davison Goodwin, seventy, said that by the time he finished climbing the CN Tower, his right hand was covered in [blisters](#) and left shoulder felt as though it were on fire. “I was terrified,” he said, recalling the day he reached the base of the tower’s observation deck, 1,100 feet (335m) above a crowd of [onlookers](#) and with no [rope](#), harness or other safety equipment. “Every move had to be perfect.” Robert, sixty-three, developed his own system for [rating](#) buildings based on how difficult they are to climb. A building’s [grips](#) mattered more than its height, he said. He gave the Brooklyn Bridge a difficulty [rating](#) of 2 out of 10 after climbing it in 1994. He gave the same [rating](#) to the Eiffel Tower, which he scaled with his [bare hands](#) in 1996. “It’s really like a [ladder](#),” he said of

the Paris landmark. Alex Honnold climbing the Taipei 101 in Taipei, Taiwan for Skyscraper Live. The [climber](#) was reportedly paid just \$500,000 by Netflix to climb the building, which he did, without a [rope](#), in January 2026. It took Honnold an hour and 31 minutes to reach the top. He was also the last person to climb Taipei 101, in 2004, then the tallest building in the world. He completed the climb just days after having surgery on his left elbow, in heavy rain and with a top [rope](#), which he said authorities had required. Robert gave Taipei 101 a [rating](#) of 6. In contrast, the small gaps on the surface of the Sydney Opera House, which he climbed in 1997 and rated as a 7, allowed him to hold on only with his [fingertips](#). In 1999, Robert scaled what he said was one of the most difficult buildings he had ever climbed, [rating](#) it a 9: the Sears Tower, now called the Willis Tower, in Chicago. He gave the Burj Khalifa in the United Arab Emirates, the world's tallest building, the same grade after climbing it in 2011. The most difficult building he ever encountered? A relatively [humble](#) forty-four-story office building west of Paris in 1998. He said the only way up the Tour Framatome, now called the Tour Areva, is by [jamming](#) one's fingers into a vertical [groove](#) between glass panels. [Halfway through](#) that climb, he said, the crack unexpectedly became so narrow that his fingers could barely fit. "It's like your entire life is hanging at the tip of your finger," he said. He rated that difficulty a 10. Some [climbers](#) said they were concerned that Honnold's climb, carried live on Netflix, would encourage [reckless](#), untrained attempts. "My message to kids: Don't do it," Goodwin said. "Unless you're a world-class [climber](#) like Alex Honnold and Alain Robert, unless you have that ability, it's a suicide mission." For others, [the danger keeps them going](#). "The only way I felt alive was when I was risking my life," Robert said, adding that he might try climbing another building in the coming weeks." Published in The New York Times on 23 January 2026. Reprinted with permission.

Glossary

- **crimps** = tacche
- **the danger keeps them going** = il pericolo li spinge ad andare avanti
- **rope** = corda
- **willing to** = disposto a
- **onlookers** = curiosi
- **groove** = fessura
- **jugs** = prese grandi, maniglie
- **stories** = piani
- **concrete gaps** = fessure nel cemento
- **rock face** = parete rocciosa
- **puzzle** = rompicapo
- **blisters** = vesciche
- **fingertips** = polpastrelli
- **overcome** = superare
- **comes down to** = ridursi a
- **slopers** = prese svase
- **tax** = mettere a dura prova
- **top rope** = corda dall'alto
- **jamming** = incastrare
- **skyscraper** = grattacielo
- **holds** = appigli, prese
- **rating** = dare un punteggio
- **grips** = appigli
- **humble** = modesto
- **reckless** = imprudenti, temerari
- **bare hands** = a mani nude
- **pullup** = trazione
- **ladder** = scala a pioli
- **Halfway through** = a metà di
- **climber** = scalatore